

LUCKNOW | Proximity Payoff

The 'K' factor is back to haunt the BJP in Uttar Pradesh. Its impact—K for Kalyan Singh and Kusum Rai—has been so strong that even former state party chief Kesrinath Tripathi and state BJP spokesman H.N. Dixit were crushed under it. Rai filed her nomination to the Rajya Sabha on November 11 to fill in the seat that party chief Rajnath Singh once occupied. A mere corporator in Lucknow just a decade ago, Rai's closeness with Kalyan Singh made her a proxy ruler of the state and she became the vice-president of Bharatiya Mahila Morcha. Her swift climb up the ladder had much to do with her mentor's pressure tactics. Though a near spent force in state politics, BJP leaders in Delhi caved in to his demands in the belief that a Kalyan spurned could turn out to be potentially dangerous for the party. Sources



RAI HAS BENEFITED FROM HER ASSOCIATION WITH KALYAN SINGH

say the reason lies with party's prime ministerial hopeful L.K. Advani who has started appeasing smaller parties. Kalyan, it is said, heads a "smaller party" within the BJP.

by Farzand Ahmed

Pay Back

American retribution is swift. Saravana Bhavan discovered it when the US Consulate in Chennai cancelled the daily order for 100 plates of idli-dosa after the owners of the popular South Indian eatery chain allegedly forged documents of employees to gain US visas.



HYDERABAD | Flying High

With Assembly elections round the corner, Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy is certainly flying high. The state has paid a whopping Rs 58 crore for a state-of-the-art

will be rented out by the fledgling Andhra Pradesh Aviation Corporation when it is not being put to official use.

by Amarnath K. Menon



golden pumpkin

THE BAD BOY of Indian cricket cannot shake off the bad news. These days, Shanthakumaran Sreesanth can neither win friends nor influence neighbours. The police paid a visit to the pace bowler's home in Bangalore's Elgin Apartments when neighbours complained that the local peace was being disturbed. No one is quite sure whether Sreesanth was hosting a birthday party (his birthday is officially listed as February 6) or merely a dozen noisy youth who also managed to engineer a minor wall collapse on his terrace. The bowler claimed he found out about the police visit only when he read the papers the following day. Sounds like a no-ball, Sree.



REUTERS